UNICEF

Oakridge JMUN 2026

United Nations Children's Fund

Agenda: Safeguarding the Rights of the Child in the Digital Age, with Special Emphasis on Minimum Age Standards for Social Media and Platform Accountability

CAR KIA
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1. Letter from the Executive Board

Honourable Delegates,

We, Sathvik Vadari, Pranay, and Arjun, in the name of the entire team, welcome you to the Oakridge International School Junior Model United Nations (OAKJMUN) in Hyderabad. We will be your Executive Board for the committee UNICEF. Please consider that the aim of this guide, as the name suggests, is to provide you with the background of the agenda solely and is by no means exhaustive. Your real research lies beyond this guide, and we hope to see strong content and debate in the conference. This background guide would serve as a starting point for your research.

The agenda at hand is a highly sensitive and relevant issue, and a successful discussion on it would entail the collective participation of all of you. Our objective, as the Executive Board of the committee, will be to facilitate debate towards developing a common understanding of how this issue impacts and affects millions of lives. It's simple if you open Google and are determined to make notes about any terminology or anything that is new to you. We are not looking for existing solutions, or strategies that would be a copy-paste of what the countries you are representing have already stated; instead, we seek an out-of-the-box solution from you, while knowing and understanding your impending practical and ideological limitations.

The delegates are advised not to limit their research only to the contents present in the guide and to acquire their research from other sources too. The Executive Board strongly recommends delegates, particularly first-timers, to thoroughly analyse your country's position on the agenda and come up with substantive proposals while keeping your country's foreign policy in mind.

Lastly, put your best foot forward as you research into the varied aspects of the agenda and display the best of your diplomatic courtesy. Feel free to revert to the Executive Board for any queries or any form of assistance that you may require during the two days of the conference.

Wishing you luck for the conference!

Sincerely,

Sathvik Vadari
Chairperson

Pranay
Vice-Chairperson

Arjun
Rapporteur

2. MUN Rules Of Procedure (ROP)

1. Roll Call

- The Chair calls on each country to declare if they are "Present" or "Present and Voting." It refers to the voting procedure on the Draft Resolution, where a delegate can vote "Yes", "No", or opt to "Abstain".
- If "Present and Voting," the delegate cannot abstain from voting. If the delegate chooses to respond with "Present", they may answer with "Present and Voting" on subsequent days, but this is not permissible for "Present and Voting" as this reply must be used consistently from that point forth.

2. Setting the Agenda

- Delegates motion to set the agenda, followed by a formal debate on which topic to discuss first. This motion requires a simple majority to pass.

3. Speakers' List

- After passing a motion to enter formal debate, delegates are placed on a speakers' list to make formal speeches. Time limits are set, and the Chair calls on delegates to speak in order.
- A delegate must raise their placard if they wish to add their name to this list. They can be on this list only once on any occasion.

4. Points

- **Point of Order:** To correct a procedural error by the Chair.
- **Point of Personal Privilege:** For personal discomfort (e.g., if the room is too cold, or if a fellow delegate cannot be heard).
- **Point of Inquiry:** To ask questions about discussion or statements in committee.
- **Point of Parliamentary Inquiry:** To ask questions with regard to the Rules of Procedure.

5. Motions

- **Motion to Suspend the Meeting:** To break for caucuses or adjourn the session.
- **Motion to Close Debate:** Ends the discussion on a topic and moves to voting. Requires a two-thirds majority.
- **Motion to Table the Topic:** Postpones debate on a topic. Requires a majority vote.

6. Yields

- **Yield to the Executive Board:** A delegate yields their remaining time from their speech to the Executive Board. It is to be used as they see fit.
- **Yield to Another Delegate:** A delegate yields their remaining time for another delegate to speak. (This delegate's permission must be sought beforehand.)
- **Yield to Points of Information:** A delegate yields their remaining time to Points of Information to the committee.
- **Yield to Comments:** A delegate yields their remaining time to comments from the committee.

7. Caucuses

- **Moderated Caucus:** The Chair controls the speaking order with shorter, focused speeches. The topic selected is a narrowed version of the agenda, chosen by the delegate who proposed the moderated caucus.
- **Unmoderated Caucus:** Informal discussion among delegates not under the moderation of the Executive Board.

8. Draft Resolutions and Amendments

- Delegates collaborate to create draft resolutions, which are formal solutions to the discussed issue.
- **Friendly Amendments:** Accepted by all sponsors without a vote.
- **Unfriendly Amendments:** Need to be voted on to be added.

9. Voting

- **Procedural Votes:** Includes motions and amendments; all members must vote.
- **Substantive Votes:** For resolutions and unfriendly amendments; only "Present and Voting" delegates may vote, and abstentions are allowed.

3. United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF)

The United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) is the UN fund for children. The UN General Assembly created it in 1946 to give emergency help to children after the Second World War. Today UNICEF works for the rights of every child. Its work rests on the Convention on the Rights of the Child (1989), which all UN member states except the United States have ratified.

UNICEF does not receive money from the regular UN budget. Voluntary contributions from governments, foundations, companies and private donors pay for all its work. A resolution that asks UNICEF to start a new programme must also say where the money will come from.

The UNICEF Executive Board governs the organisation. It has 36 member states. The Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) elects these states for terms of three years. Each region has a fixed number of seats: Africa 8, Asia 7, Eastern Europe 4, Latin America and the Caribbean 5, and Western Europe and Others 12. The UNICEF Executive Board meets three times each year. It reviews the work of UNICEF and approves its policies, country programmes and budgets.

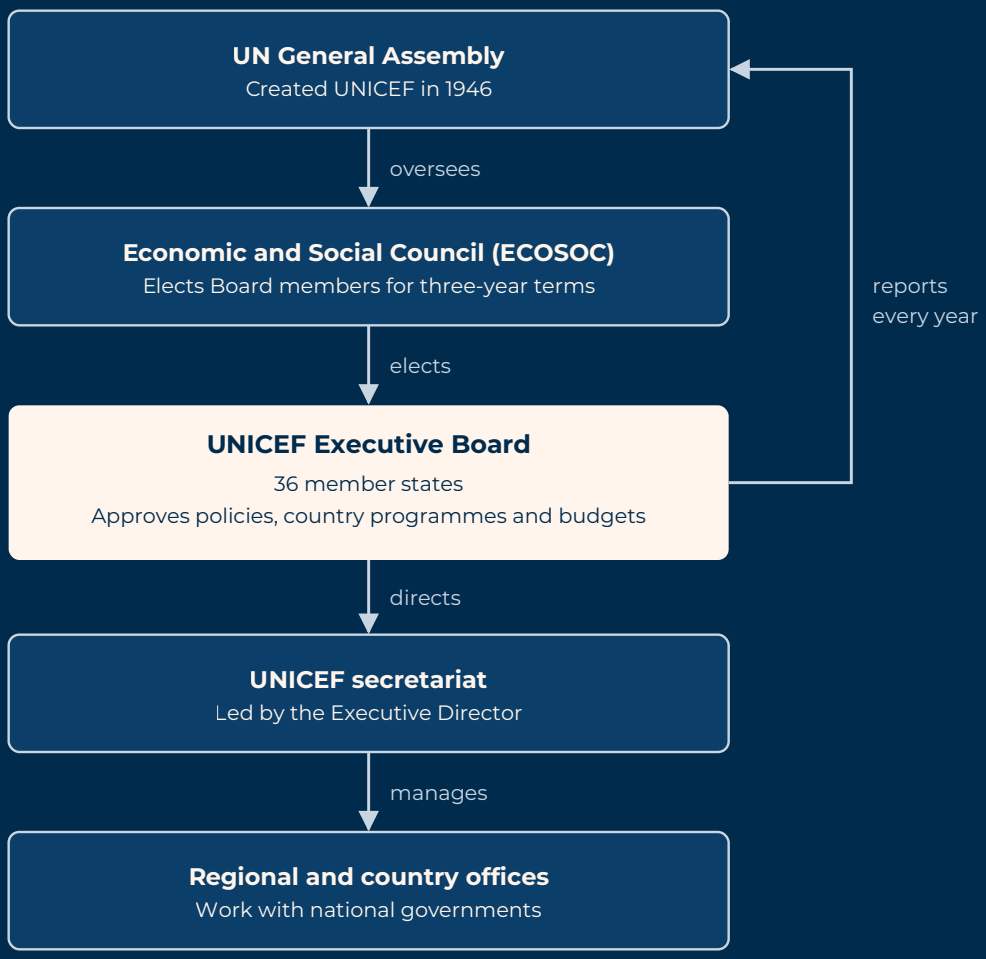


Figure 1. Where UNICEF sits in the UN system

Source: UNICEF Executive Board; UNICEF Executive Board orientation, 2024

4. Mandate of the Committee

The decisions of the UNICEF Executive Board instruct UNICEF. They do not bind member states. When the UNICEF Executive Board wants a government to act, it can only recommend or encourage. This difference sets the limits of this committee. A resolution can tell UNICEF what to study, what guidance to publish, which programmes to support and which governments to help. A resolution cannot make a national law, ban an application, or put a penalty on a company. Those powers belong to national parliaments, national regulators and national courts.

For this agenda, UNICEF has five main tools. First, it gives technical help to governments that write new laws or set up regulators. Second, it collects and publishes data on children, for example through its research programme Global Kids

Online. Third, it writes guidance for governments and companies. Fourth, it runs programmes in schools and communities, such as digital skills training for children and parents. Fifth, it brings governments, companies, experts and children together to agree on common standards.

Figure 2 shows how a resolution of this committee can lead to change. UNICEF can act directly through its own programmes. It can also act indirectly: it helps member states, the states pass laws and create regulators, the regulators enforce the rules, and the platforms change their services. Most of the change in this agenda happens through the second route. For this reason, a strong resolution says what UNICEF will do, and it also says what UNICEF recommends to member states.

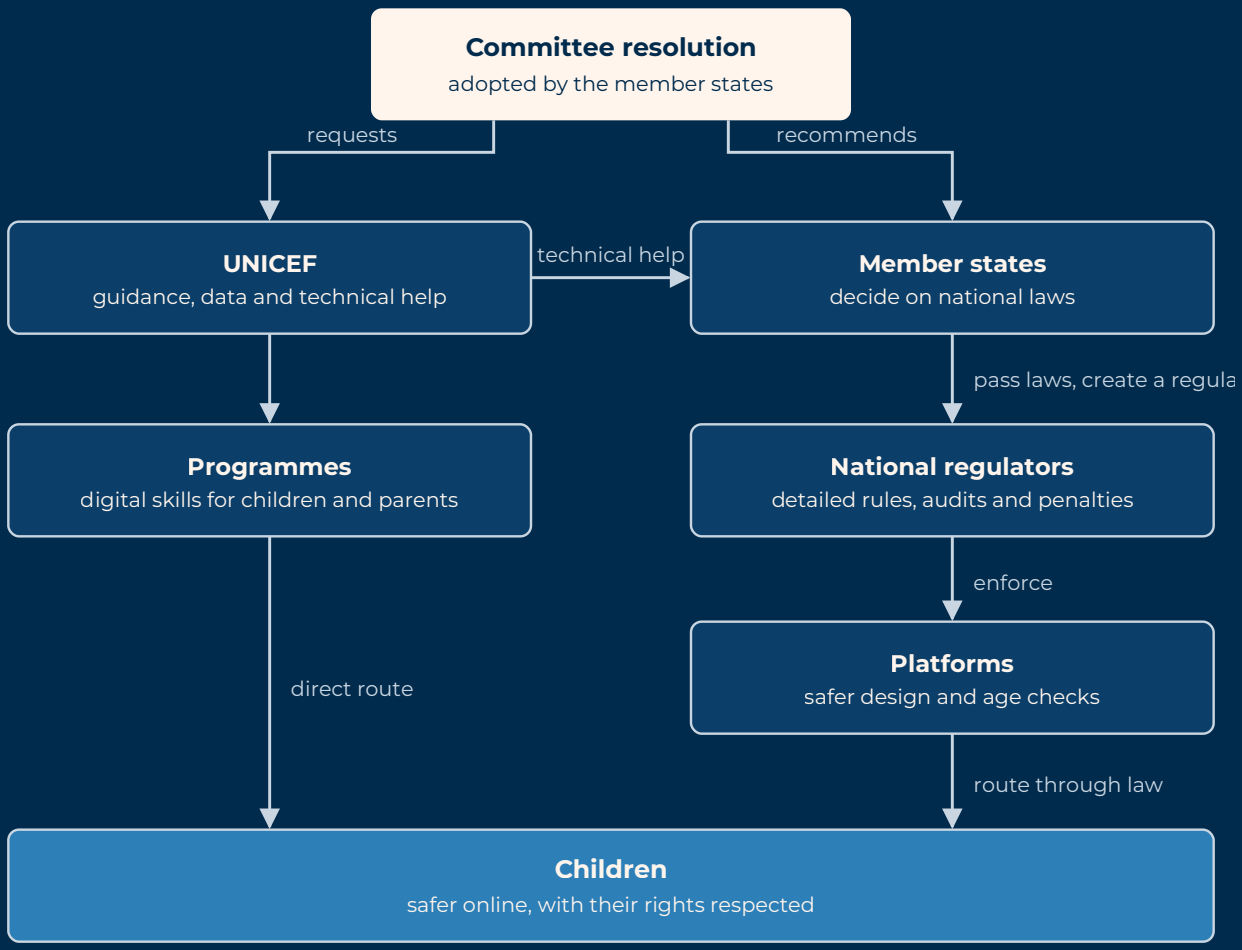


Figure 2. How a resolution of this committee can lead to change for children

Source: prepared by the Executive Board

In Simple Terms

This committee plays the role of the body that directs UNICEF. It can ask UNICEF to study, advise, fund and help. It can also give advice to governments. Governments then decide whether to make laws, and regulators and courts then decide how to enforce them.

In this conference, each delegate represents one member state. The committee has the same powers as the UNICEF Executive Board, but it has more members than the real body. Debate must stay on the rights and safety of children in the digital environment. Wider disputes between states, elections and cybercrime are outside the agenda.

5. The Agenda

Agenda: Safeguarding the Rights of the Child in the Digital Age, with Special Emphasis on Minimum Age Standards for Social Media and Platform Accountability

5.1 Introduction

The agenda asks how states can protect children online and also respect their rights. Two policy answers now compete. The first answer is a **minimum age standard**. Under this answer, children under a set age cannot hold an account on a social media platform. The second answer is **platform accountability**. Under this answer, companies must design their services to be safe for children, and they must answer for harm that their design causes.

A state can use both answers, and many states now do. The debate is about the balance between them and about the rights that each answer affects. A minimum age can protect children from some harm, but it can also limit their access to information, friends and support. An age check makes a minimum age possible, but it can collect personal data from every user, adult or child. A duty of care for companies can make apps safer for everyone, but a state needs a strong regulator to enforce it.

The agenda is also urgent. Until 2025, few states had a minimum age for social media. Platforms set their own minimum age, usually 13, and often did not check it. Since December 2025, Australia, Indonesia, Brazil and Malaysia have started national rules, and many other states have announced plans. This committee meets while these rules are new and the evidence on their effect is incomplete.

5.2 Terms Used in This Guide

Term	Meaning
Child	Any person under the age of 18 (Article 1 of the Convention on the Rights of the Child).
Minimum age standard	The lowest age at which a person can hold an account on a service. A standard can be a law or a recommendation.
Platform accountability	The duty of a company to make its service safe, and to answer for harm, through rules, audits, reports, courts or penalties.
Age assurance	Any method that checks or estimates the age of a user. It includes age verification, age estimation and age inference.
Age verification	A check of age against an official record, such as a national identity card.
Age estimation	An estimate of age from a face, a voice or another physical feature.
Safety by design	A principle under which a company builds safety into a service from the start.
Duty of care	A legal duty for a company to prevent harm to its users that it can foresee.
Recommender system	The software that selects which posts or videos a user sees next.
Regulator	A public body that writes detailed rules and checks that companies obey them, for example eSafety in Australia or Ofcom in the United Kingdom.

6. Timeline: How the Rules Changed

For many years, the main rules for children online were rules about data. Between 2024 and 2026, many states moved to rules about access and design.

Date	Event
2021	
Mar	**General Comment No. 25** The UN Committee on the Rights of the Child states that children's rights apply online.
2023	
Aug	**India passes the DPDP Act** Platforms need parental consent before they use the data of children under 18.
Nov	**UN General Assembly resolution** States agree by consensus to apply the Convention in the digital environment.
2024	
Nov 28	**Australia passes its law** Parliament sets 16 as the minimum age for listed social media platforms.
2025	
Sep 17	**Brazil enacts the Digital ECA** Accounts of young users must link to the account of a parent.
Nov 26	**European Parliament vote** Members call for an EU-wide minimum age of 16, by 483 votes to 92.
Dec 10	**Australia's ban starts** UNICEF warns on the same day that bans alone will not keep children safe.
2026	

Mar 17	**Brazil's law takes effect** The data protection authority ANPD supervises the law.
Mar 24 to 25	**Two US juries find Meta liable** Courts in New Mexico and Los Angeles rule against Meta.
Mar 28	**Indonesia starts PP Tunas** Under-16 accounts close on 8 high-risk platforms, in stages.
Apr	**Türkiye passes an under-15 ban** The law adds parental controls for children aged 15 to 17.
Jun 1	**Malaysia's ban starts** Large platforms must block users under 16.
Jun 15	**The UK announces an under-16 ban** The first rules are due in spring 2027.
Aug 14	**France's ban is struck down** The Conseil constitutionnel finds the limit on free expression too wide.
Aug 26	**Meta settles with US states** Meta agrees to pay up to 17.1 billion US dollars and to change its apps for teenagers.
Sep 16	**The EU announces the Kids Act** The plan: no social media under 13, and parent-managed accounts until 15.
Sep 28	**India plans limits for under-18s** The Centre tells the Supreme Court that it will amend the IT Rules.

Sources: Child Rights Connect; Child Rights Connect; MediaNama; Wikipedia tracker of age laws; Revera; UN News; Bernama; GOV.UK; NPR; CNN; CNN.

7. Children Online: What the Data Shows

Most children in the countries of this committee are online, and many of them use social media every week. Research shows two things at the same time. Problematic use of social media is rising, and social media also gives many children support and access to information.

7.1 India

The Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) 2024 surveyed children aged 14 to 16 in rural India. Almost 90% had a smartphone at home, and 82.2% could use one. Of the children who could use a smartphone, 76% used social media in the week before the survey, but only 57% used the phone for study. Boys used social media more than girls.

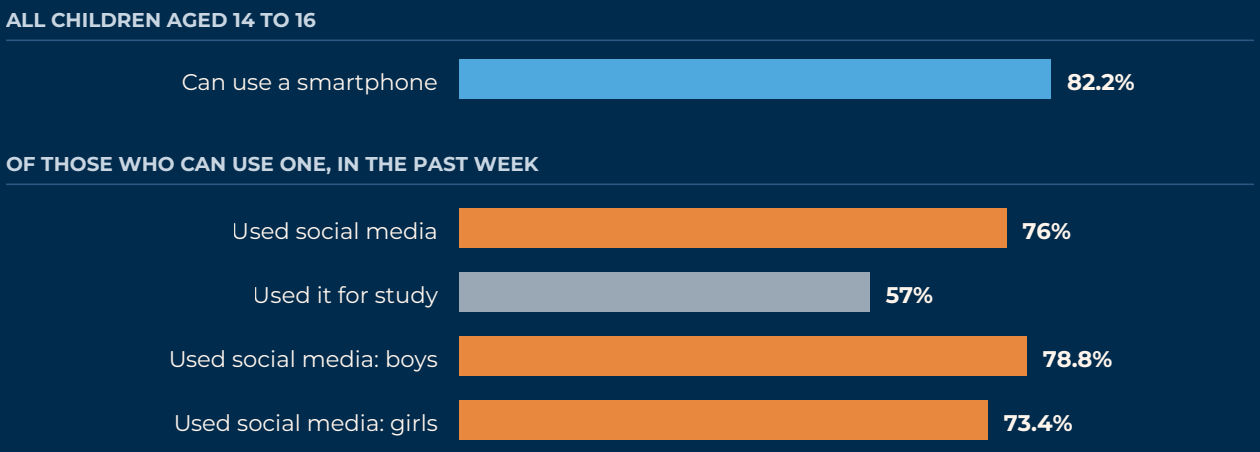


Figure 3. Smartphone and social media use among rural children aged 14 to 16 in India, 2024

Source: ASER 2024, Press Information Bureau factsheet

7.2 Europe, Central Asia and Canada

The Health Behaviour in School-aged Children (HBSC) study of the World Health Organization surveyed almost 280,000 children aged 11, 13 and 15 in 44 countries and regions in 2022. The study counts social media use as problematic when it shows signs like addiction, such as loss of control and harm to daily life. Problematic use rose from 7% in 2018 to 11% in 2022, and it was higher among girls than among boys. The same study found that heavy users without problematic use had stronger support from their friends.

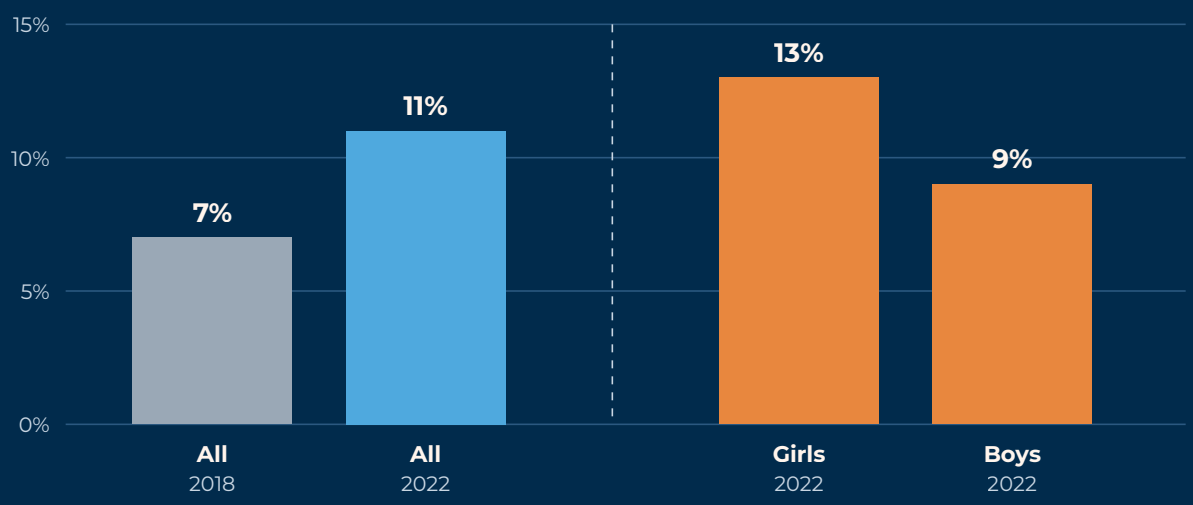


Figure 4. Adolescents with problematic social media use, 2018 and 2022

Source: WHO Europe; HBSC highlights; Research Live

8. Minimum Age Laws around the World

Most governments that set a minimum age choose 15 or 16. The full range runs from 13 to 18, and many rules are still plans or bills. The rules also differ in who must act. In Australia and Indonesia, the platform must act. In Brazil, the account of a young user must link to a parent. In China, devices, applications and app stores must provide a "minor mode" with time limits. In India, the current law controls data, and it does not yet control access.

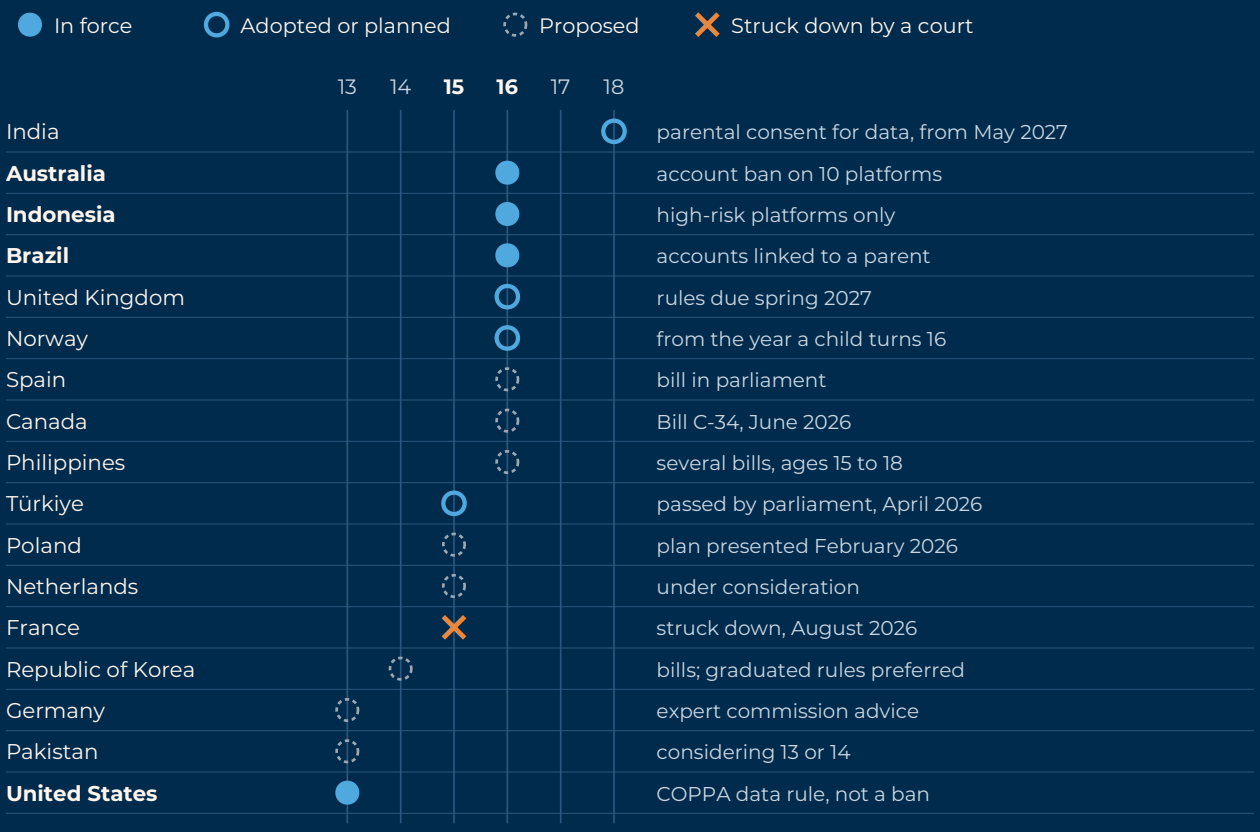


Figure 5. Minimum ages for social media accounts, by state and status, October 2026

Source: national sources in Table 1; Wikipedia tracker of age laws for Türkiye, the Philippines, Poland, the Netherlands, the Republic of Korea and Pakistan; Revera

Table 1. Main national approaches

State	Approach	Status in October 2026
Australia	Ban on 10 listed platforms. Platforms must take "reasonable steps". Children and parents face no penalty.	In force since 10 December 2025
Indonesia	Ban on 8 high-risk platforms. Lower-risk platforms are open from the age of 13.	In force in stages since 28 March 2026
Brazil	Accounts of young users link to a parent. Companies have a duty of care.	In force since 17 March 2026
China	Minor mode: 1 hour a day under 16, 2 hours from 16 to 18, and no use from 10 pm to 6 am. Parents can change the limits.	In force since 2024
India	Parental consent before a platform uses the data of a child. No age limit for accounts yet.	Consent duty from 13 May 2027

Source: AusLume summary of eSafety; Bernama; TechCrunch; Mayer Brown; Digital Policy Alert; MediaNama

8.1 The Enforcement Gap across Borders

A national law applies only inside one country, but a platform works in almost every country at the same time. Most large platforms belong to companies based in the United States or China, and many run their European business from Ireland. A government can pass a law for its own children, but it must then make a foreign company obey that law.

States use different tools to close this gap. In March 2026, Indonesia summoned Meta and Google because they did not enforce its under-16 limit (Malay Mail). The European Union gives the European Commission direct power over the largest platforms, so that one regulator acts for all 27 member states. In 2026, the Commission issued preliminary findings against TikTok and Meta on addictive design and the protection of children (Revera). In Australia, the regulator can investigate a platform, but only a court can order a penalty (AusLume).

Children can also move across this gap. When a large platform blocks them, some children move to smaller platforms that no regulator watches, as UNICEF warned

(UN News). Human Rights Council resolution 59/23 calls for international cooperation to support national frameworks for children in the digital space (OHCHR).

9. How Age Checks Work

A minimum age law works only as well as its age check. Figure 6 shows the steps of a typical law and the route that enforcement takes when a check fails. Each check method has a different balance between accuracy and privacy. The most accurate methods usually collect the most personal data (Squire Patton Boggs).

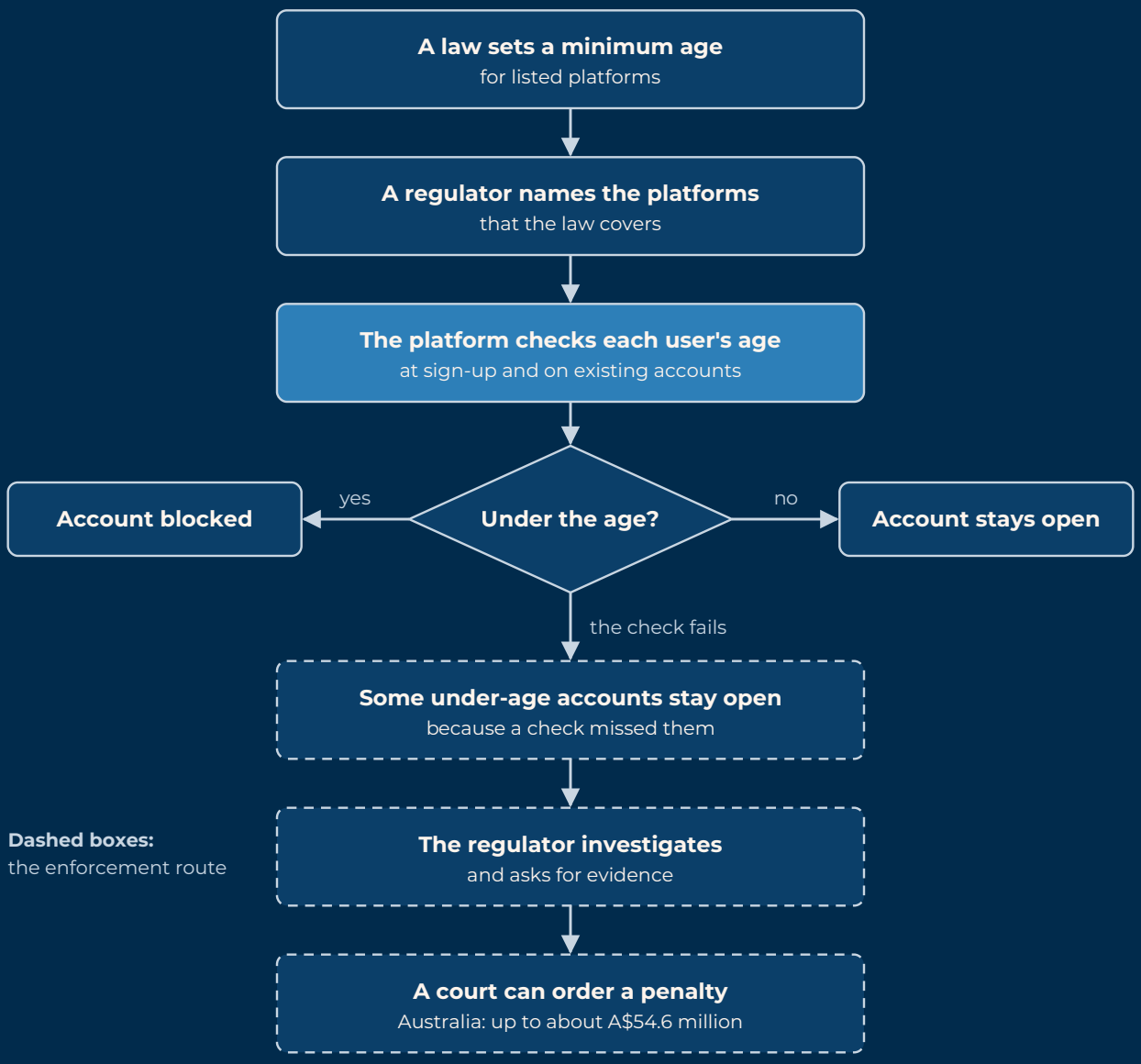


Figure 6. How a minimum age law works, and how it is enforced

Source: Australian model, AusLume summary of eSafety

Table 2. Age check methods

Method	How it works	Main strength	Main weakness
Self-declaration	The user types a date of birth.	Easy and free	Easy to lie. Australia's regulator no longer accepts it.
Identity document	The platform checks an official ID.	High accuracy	Excludes children without ID, and collects sensitive data.
Face estimation	Software estimates age from a photograph.	No ID needed	More errors for users aged 16 to 20 and for darker skin.
Behaviour inference	Software estimates age from activity on the app.	No extra step	Needs data on what the user does.
Parental consent	A parent approves the account or the use of data.	Families keep control	Puts the burden on parents. Many children use a parent's phone.
Digital ID proof	A digital ID confirms one fact, such as "over 16", and nothing more.	Shares the least data	Needs a national digital ID system.

Source: Bird and Bird; Squire Patton Boggs; Revera; MediaNama

Evidence from the first years shows the limits of age checks. In Australia, 66.8% of parents whose child kept an account said that the platform never asked the child to verify their age (AusLume). In the United Kingdom, 39% of children bypassed age checks, mostly because they gave a false age (MediaNama). In 2025, a hack of an age-check company may have exposed the identity photos of 70,000 users of Discord (Wikipedia tracker). Australia's national trial found that age checks can work privately and well, but that no single method fits every case (Age Assurance Technology Trial).

10. Case Studies

10.1 Australia: The First National Ban

Since 10 December 2025, platforms in Australia must take "reasonable steps" to stop users under 16 from holding accounts. The law covers 10 platforms, including Facebook, Instagram, Snapchat, TikTok and YouTube. The duty falls on platforms, and children and parents face no penalty. A court can order a platform to pay up to about 54.6 million Australian dollars.

Platforms removed or restricted 4.7 million accounts by mid-December 2025, although Australia has only 2.5 million children aged 8 to 15. Many children therefore held more than one account. A survey of 898 parents in early 2026 shows that the share of children with an account fell by more than a third. The same survey shows that most children who had Snapchat, TikTok or Instagram still had those accounts.

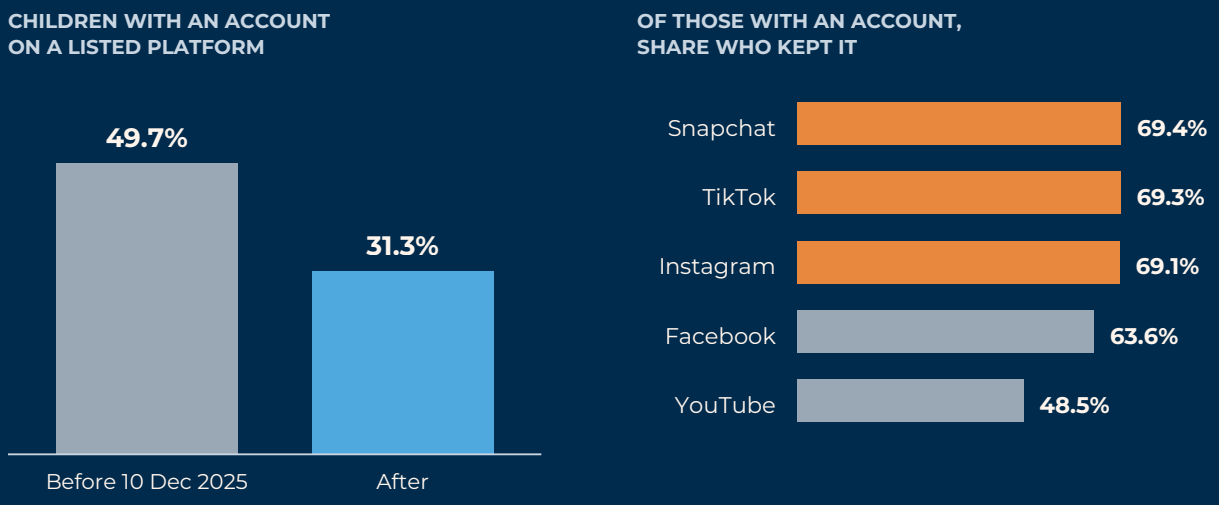


Figure 7. Children aged 8 to 15 with social media accounts in Australia, before and after the ban

Source: eSafety compliance update, March 2026, via AusLume; eSafety

10.2 United States: Platform Accountability through the Courts

The United States has no national minimum age for social media. Instead, in 2026, courts and state governments made platforms answer for the design of their services. In March 2026, a Los Angeles jury found Meta and YouTube liable for harm that addictive design caused to a young user. In the same month, a New Mexico jury found that Meta misled users about safety. In August 2026, Meta settled with 51 state attorneys general. It agreed to a default limit of two hours a day for teenage

accounts, which only a parent can remove, and to an independent auditor (Quartz). Meta did not admit wrongdoing.

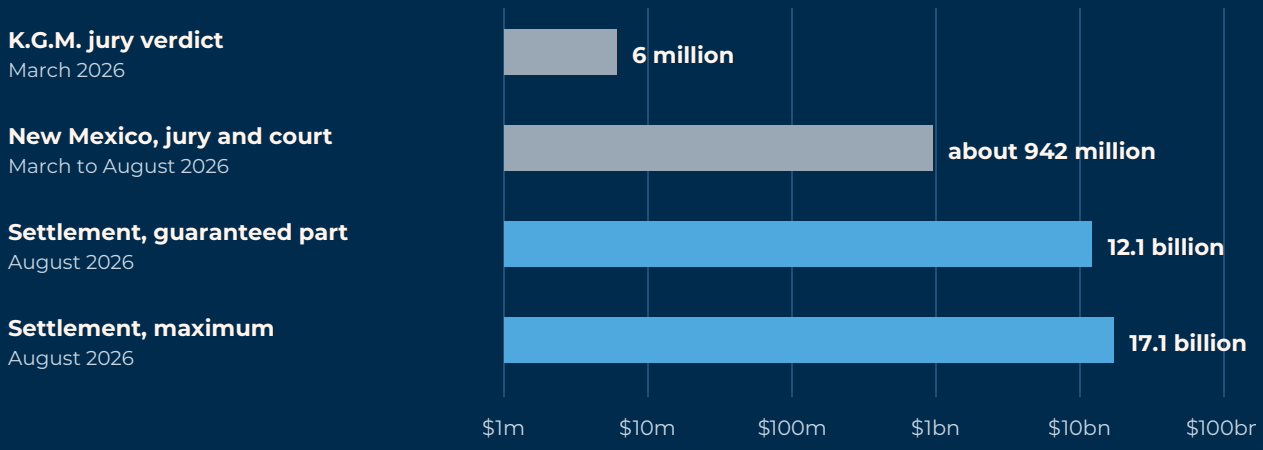


Figure 8. Amounts in the main US cases against Meta, 2026 (log scale)

Source: NPR; CNN; Social Media Victims Law Center; Revera

These are national court cases, and UNICEF was not a party to them. They show the committee a second model: rules on design, enforced by courts and regulators, without an age ban.

10.3 India: Consent First, with a Ban under Discussion

India has no minimum age for social media accounts. The Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 requires verifiable parental consent before a platform uses the data of anyone under 18, and it bars targeted advertisements aimed at children. This duty starts on 13 May 2027. In 2026, Karnataka announced an under-16 ban but did not introduce a bill, and 438 scientists asked for a pause on age-based controls. On 28 September 2026, the Centre told the Supreme Court that it will amend the IT Rules to stop users under 18 from opening accounts (MediaNama). Many Indian children use a parent's phone, so any age check in India must deal with shared devices.

11. Existing International Framework

Only one text in this section binds states: the Convention on the Rights of the Child. The other texts guide states. Delegates should quote them to show that their proposals follow agreed UN language.

Table 3. International texts

Text	Year	Binding	What it says for this agenda
Convention on the Rights of the Child	1989	Yes	Sets the rights that every age rule and every platform rule must respect.
General Comment No. 25	2021	No	Children's rights apply online. States are responsible for the conduct of companies in their territory.
General Assembly resolution on the rights of the child in the digital environment	2023	No	Adopted by consensus. Asks states to apply the Convention online, including the right to privacy.
Human Rights Council resolution 56/6	2024	No	Sets the safety of children online as a shared goal.
Human Rights Council resolution 59/23	2025	No	Calls for cooperation and technical help for national frameworks.
UNICEF Strategic Plan, 2026 to 2029	2025	Approved by the UNICEF Executive Board	Sets the priorities of UNICEF. Resolutions can ask UNICEF to act within it.

Source: OHCHR; Child Rights Connect; Child Rights Connect; UNICEF

Table 4. Articles of the Convention that apply

Article	Right	Link to this agenda
3	Best interests of the child	Every rule must show how it serves children.
5	Evolving capacities	Older children can need different rules from younger children.
12	The right to be heard	Children must have a say in rules about them.
13	Freedom of expression and information	An age ban limits this right, so it must be necessary.
16	Privacy	Age checks collect personal data.
17	Access to information, with protection from harmful material	This article contains both sides of the debate.
19	Protection from violence and abuse	Cyberbullying and contact from harmful adults.

12. Links for Further Study

The following links are a starting point for research. Do not limit your research to this background guide.

UN and UNICEF

- UNICEF statement on age bans, December 2025
- UNICEF Executive Board membership
- OHCHR: children's rights in the digital environment
- WHO Europe: HBSC data on social media use

Governments and Regulators

- eSafety Commissioner: social media age restrictions
- GOV.UK: under-16 ban announcement

- Bernama: Indonesia begins PP Tunas
- ASER 2024 factsheet, India

Courts and Companies

- NPR: the K.G.M. verdict
- CNN: the Meta settlement
- Quartz: terms of the settlement

Analysis

- Wikipedia: social media age laws by country
- Revera: the EU Kids Act and national laws in Europe
- MediaNama: India and the Supreme Court
- AusLume: Australia's first three months

13. Questions a Resolution Must Answer (QARMA)

QARMA stands for Questions A Resolution Must Answer. When delegates write a draft resolution or decide the flow of the committee, they must keep the questions below in mind.

1. Should UNICEF recommend a minimum age for social media accounts? If yes, should it recommend one age for all states, or a range that each state can choose from?
2. Which services must a minimum age cover, and which services must stay outside it, for example messaging, education services or games?
3. Which standards should UNICEF promote for age checks, so that checks protect privacy and do not exclude children without identity documents?
4. How should rules treat children who use a parent's phone, or who live in places with weak internet access?
5. Which features of apps should states limit for users under 18, and what should safety by design mean in practice?
6. Which powers should national regulators hold, such as audits, public reports or penalties? How can UNICEF help states that have no regulator?

7. How can these measures protect children and also respect their rights to information, expression and participation under Articles 12, 13 and 17?
8. How should children take part in the design of these rules?
9. Who will pay for each measure, and how will UNICEF measure whether it works?